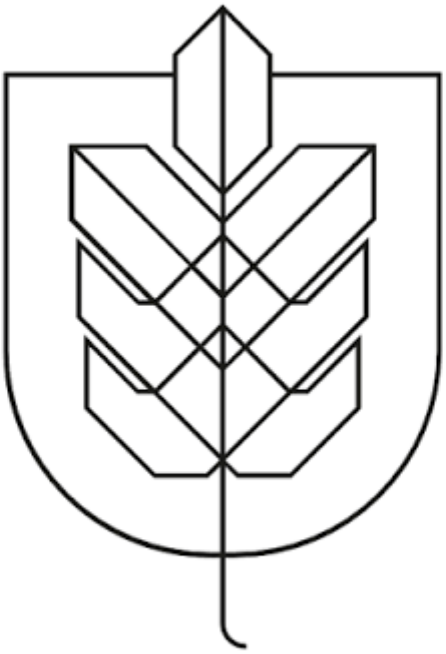


Teamwork and collaboration
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Reflective Team Debrief

1. Introduction and Context

This memorandum evaluates our teamwork during the production of a 30-second television advertisement. While completing the advert was important, our most significant learning emerged from collaboration, managing creative tension, applying structured frameworks, and balancing persuasive strategy with ethical responsibility.

Our objectives were to create an emotionally resonant advert for 18–24-year-olds, meet all project requirements, and apply course frameworks in a real team context. We used Belbin's Team Roles to align strengths with responsibilities and the Six Thinking Hats to structure discussions. DISC insights enhanced our understanding of communication styles.

We assessed performance using criteria including message coherence, audience alignment, production execution, and framework application, rating our work 9/10 overall. However, our use of frameworks was sometimes superficial, particularly under time pressure, with members defaulting to familiar roles or skipping stages of the Six Thinking Hats process. This reduced their collaborative impact and highlighted the need for more consistent integration in future projects.

2. Team Structure, Roles, and Project Planning

From the outset, we prioritised clarity in roles to minimise confusion. Using Belbin's framework, we aligned responsibilities with strengths, including facilitation, strategy, creativity, editing, documentation, and execution. Although roles were defined, decision-making remained collective, balancing accountability with shared ownership.

We often operated within the Green Hat space, generating ideas and energising discussion. Our creative contributions expanded possibilities and encouraged unconventional thinking.

The balance between divergent (Green Hat) and convergent (Black Hat) thinking was effective. However, structure alone did not prevent creative friction. During early ideation, we moved too quickly to critique, discarding ideas prematurely. After recognising this, we introduced timed Green Hat sessions before evaluation. This adjustment increased idea diversity and encouraged fuller participation.

3. Communication, Psychological Safety, and Diversity

Psychological safety was a core strength. The environment allowed open idea sharing without fear of judgment and enabled smooth transitions from exploration to execution.

We experienced communication challenges when aligning perspectives. Differences in personality, culture, and working style created friction. High C profiles preferred structure, while creative profiles favoured flexibility.

Rather than suppressing differences, we leveraged them. DISC helped us interpret behaviours as stylistic differences rather than personal conflict. Analytical caution became risk management; creative expansion became innovation. By filming and editing, collaboration was more fluid, roles clearer, and trust stronger.

4. Creativity, Strategy, and Decision-Making

Our creative process combined structured frameworks with behavioural marketing insight. The Six Thinking Hats method guided transitions between idea generation and evaluation, preserving creative flow when applied intentionally.

Structured feasibility analysis ensured concepts remained technically achievable. This was critical when balancing creative ambition with practical constraints. The negotiation exercise reinforced the value of questioning assumptions. We learned that constraints and iteration enhance creativity rather than restrict it.

5. Conflict Management and Tuckman's Stages

Our experience reflected Tuckman's stages. During forming, roles and expectations were clarified. In storming, disagreements arose regarding concept direction and feasibility. Repeated revisions slowed progress and caused occasional frustration.

We improved conflict management by clearly separating idea generation from critique. During the performing stage, particularly in filming and post-production, trust was evident. We concluded that indecision posed a greater risk to progress than open disagreement.

6. Ethical Reflection

Ethical considerations were actively discussed. During scripting, we debated whether implying significant lifestyle transformation risked misleading the 18–24 audience. Our reflection was largely reactive, addressing concerns as they emerged rather than following a structured process.

To strengthen ethical integration, we plan to embed predetermined checkpoints throughout each project phase. For example, ethics could function as an additional "Hat" within the Six Thinking Hats method, prompting explicit evaluation of implications alongside creative and technical perspectives. Similarly, we could assign ethical monitoring responsibility within Belbin-based role allocation to ensure accountability.

These structured checkpoints would enable earlier identification of risks related to misrepresentation, emotional impact, and societal influence. This experience reinforced that ethical marketing leadership requires transparency alongside commercial objectives.

7. Key Lessons and Next Steps

Consistent frameworks use enhanced collaboration, particularly through clearer role allocation and structured idea evaluation. However, differences in communication styles occasionally created tension, especially during time-sensitive decisions. For example, when selecting the advert's central theme, opposing views led to temporary stalemate before reverting to the Six Thinking Hats for resolution.

This demonstrated that while frameworks and psychological safety support collaboration, they do not eliminate conflict, highlighting the need for active conflict management.

For future campaigns, we will:
- Begin with a concise team charter including ethical checkpoints.
- Apply Six Thinking Hats explicitly during ideation and evaluation.
- Establish early decision freeze points.
- Continue using DISC insights to tailor communication.
- Conduct informal test screenings before final production.

This project strengthened our ability to collaborate under pressure and translate theory into practice. By refining team structure, maintaining psychological safety, and embedding ethical review, we aim to enhance performance and demonstrate responsible leadership in future marketing initiatives.

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